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WHO recommendations on **maternal and newborn care for a positive postnatal experience**



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Care category	Recommendation	Category of recommendation
Physical activity and sedentary behaviour[10]	**22.** All postpartum women without contraindication should: • undertake regular physical activity throughout the postpartum period; • do at least 150 minutes of physical activity throughout the week for substantial health benefits; and • incorporate a variety of physical and muscle-strengthening activities; adding gentle stretching may also be beneficial.	Recommended
	23. Postpartum women should limit the amount of time spent being sedentary. Replacing sedentary time with physical activity of any intensity (including light intensity) provides health benefits.	Recommended
Contraception		
Postpartum contraception[11]	**24.** Provision of comprehensive contraceptive information and services during postnatal care is recommended.	Recommended
B. NEWBORN CARE		
Newborn assessment		
Assessment of the newborn for danger signs[12]	**25.** The following signs should be assessed during each postnatal care contact, and the newborn should be referred for further evaluation if any of the signs is present: not feeding well; history of convulsions; fast breathing (breathing rate > 60 per minute); severe chest in-drawing; no spontaneous movement; fever (temperature > 37.5 °C); low body temperature (temperature < 35.5 °C); any jaundice in first 24 hours after birth, or yellow palms and soles at any age. The parents and family should be encouraged to seek health care early if they identify any of the above danger signs between postnatal care visits.	Recommended
Universal screening for abnormalities of the eye	**26.** Universal newborn screening for abnormalities of the eye is recommended and should be accompanied by diagnostic and management services for children identified with an abnormality.	Recommended
Universal screening for hearing impairment	**27.** Universal newborn hearing screening (UNHS) with otoacoustic emissions (OAE) or automated auditory brainstem response (AABR) is recommended for early identification of permanent bilateral hearing loss (PBHL). UNHS should be accompanied by diagnostic and management services for children identified with hearing loss.	Recommended
Universal screening for neonatal hyperbilirubinaemia	**28.** Universal screening for neonatal hyperbilirubinaemia by transcutaneous bilirubinometer (TcB) is recommended at health facility discharge.	Recommended
	29. There is insufficient evidence to recommend for or against universal screening by total serum bilirubin (TSB) at health facility discharge.	No recommendation issued
Preventive measures		
Timing of first bath to prevent hypothermia and its sequelae	**30.** The first bath of a term, healthy newborn should be delayed for at least 24 hours after birth.	Recommended
Use of emollients for the prevention of skin conditions	**31.** Routine application of topical emollients in term, healthy newborns for the prevention of skin conditions is not recommended.	Not recommended

10 Adapted and integrated from the 2020 *WHO guidelines on physical activity and sedentary behaviour.*

11 Adapted and integrated from the 2013 WHO document *Ensuring human rights in the provision of contraceptive information and services: guidance and recommendations.*

12 Adapted and integrated from the 2014 *WHO recommendations on postnatal care of the mother and newborn.*

Care category	Recommendation	Category of recommendation
Breastfeeding		
Exclusive breastfeeding[15]	**42.** All babies should be exclusively breastfed from birth until 6 months of age. Mothers should be counselled and provided with support for exclusive breastfeeding at each postnatal contact.	Recommended
Protecting, promoting and supporting breastfeeding in facilities providing maternity and newborn services[16]	**43a.** Facilities providing maternity and newborn services should have a clearly written breastfeeding policy that is routinely communicated to staff and parents.	Recommended
	43b. Health-facility staff who provide infant feeding services, including breastfeeding support, should have sufficient knowledge, competence and skills to support women to breastfeed.	Recommended

C. HEALTH SYSTEMS AND HEALTH PROMOTION INTERVENTIONS		
Schedules for postnatal care contacts	**44.** A minimum of four postnatal care contacts is recommended. If birth is in a health facility, healthy women and newborns should receive postnatal care in the facility for at least 24 hours after birth. If birth is at home, the first postnatal contact should be as early as possible within 24 hours of birth. At least three additional postnatal contacts are recommended for healthy women and newborns, between 48 and 72 hours, between 7 and 14 days, and during week six after birth.	Recommended
Length of stay in health facilities after birth	**45.** Care for healthy women and newborns in the health facility is recommended for at least 24 hours after vaginal birth.	Recommended
Criteria to be assessed prior to discharge from the health facility after birth	**46.** Prior to discharging women and newborns after birth from the health facility to the home, health workers should assess the following criteria to improve maternal and newborn outcomes: • the woman's and baby's physical well-being and the woman's emotional well-being; • the skills and confidence of the woman to care for herself and the skills and confidence of the parents and caregivers to care for the newborn; and • the home environment and other factors that may influence the ability to provide care for the woman and the newborn in the home, and care-seeking behaviour.	Recommended
Approaches to strengthen preparation for discharge from the health facility to home after birth	**47.** Information provision, educational interventions and counselling are recommended to prepare women, parents and caregivers for discharge from the health facility after birth to improve maternal and newborn health outcomes, and to facilitate the transition to the home. Educational materials, such as written/digital education booklets, pictorials for semi-literate populations and job aids should be available.	Recommended
Home visits for postnatal care contacts	**48.** Home visits during the first week after birth by skilled health personnel or a trained community health worker are recommended for the postnatal care of healthy women and newborns. Where home visits are not feasible or not preferred, outpatient postnatal care contacts are recommended.	Recommended

15 Integrated from the 2014 *WHO recommendations on postnatal care of the mother and newborn.*

16 Integrated from the 2017 WHO guideline *Protecting, promoting and supporting breastfeeding in facilities providing maternity and newborn services.*